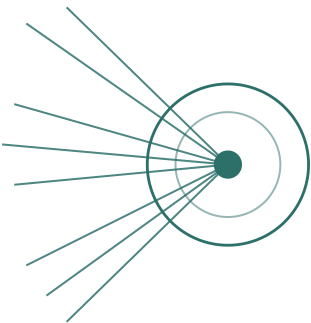


Cleo

DAILY

Field notes for people who build products — filtered, so you can stop scrolling.



TODAY,
IN ONE LINE

Two questions are quietly reshaping how products get built: what to charge for AI — and where the power to run it comes from.

IN THIS ISSUE

02 **The One Thing**
Pay per token, not per seat

04 **From Hacker News**
The orange site, read for you

05 **Signals**
The world, in passing

06 **Deep Dive**
The bottleneck is the grid

07 **Evidence**
The numbers & the jobs debate

20 PP. · 6 LENSES

09 **Spotlight**
The agent war moves to your devices

11 **Craft**
Price the verb, not the seat

14 **Science & Wonder**
An 80-year problem, cracked

16 **The Long View**
In defence of permanent doubt

18 **Puzzles**
Connections, trivia & more

IF YOU READ NOTHING ELSE TODAY

Pay per token, not per seat.

The story isn't only the AI bill — it's the pricing model behind it. Exponential View argues AI is sliding off flat per-seat subscriptions onto metered, pay-per-use pricing — the same trip the internet ad market made from CPM to cost-per-action. If you price anything, this is the quarter it reaches you.

The logic is hard to argue with. Per-seat pricing made sense when a product's value tracked who had a login. AI's value tracks *work done* — tokens spent, tasks finished, agents run — and a flat seat can't see any of that. So the meter moves to the verb. Exponential View's framing this week: we're repeating the web's journey from bundled, flat fees to metered, performance-linked ones, only far faster.

Uber's new spending cap is the same coin's other face. When you meter usage, the bill becomes variable — and a variable bill needs a cap, or it terrifies the buyer. Uber's \$1,500-a-month ceiling per engineer wasn't anti-AI; it

was the guardrail that makes metered pricing survivable on the buyer's side.

For a product manager, three decisions just got promoted from billing footnotes to roadmap items: *the unit* (what verb do you meter?), *the meter* (can the customer see and trust it?), and *the guardrail* (what stops a runaway bill?). Get them wrong and even a beloved product churns on its invoice.

The opportunity is the mirror image: usage pricing aligns what you charge with the value you create, and it lets small customers start cheap and grow into big ones. The seat was a proxy. The token is the thing itself.

SO WHAT — FOR YOU

Pricing is product now. Before next planning, name the unit of value you'd meter, decide whether the customer can see it, and set the cap — before finance sets it for you.

*“The seat was always a proxy.
The token is the thing itself.”*

Compiled from **Exponential View** (3 Jun) & **Simon Willison** on Uber's cap (3 Jun).

§ The Brief

SIX THINGS WORTH YOUR ATTENTION
THE VERDICT TELLS YOU HOW MUCH

[READ](#)

Google opens Gemma 4 12B — multimodal, encoder-free

A unified model that handles text and images without a separate vision encoder, tuned for efficiency. Open weights at a size you can actually run — a real option for agentic and on-device work.

► GOOGLE · 3 JUN

[SAVE](#)

Microsoft's Project Solara reframes the PC as an agent endpoint

Stratechery's read: Solara points at devices as spokes to cloud agents, and suddenly Nvidia's shiny RTX “AI PC” looks like last era's idea. The fight over *where* AI runs is leaving the browser.

► STRATECHERY · 3 JUN

[READ](#)

Google is financing a virtual power plant for its data centres

Via Voltus, a ~100MW programme pays homes and businesses to cut usage, freeing grid capacity on the US East Coast. The clearest sign yet that AI's real constraint is electricity.

► MIT TECH REVIEW · 3 JUN

[READ](#)

An economist's case against the AI jobs-pocalypse

Labour economist Kathryn Anne Edwards argues mass AI unemployment is unlikely; the real failure would be an inadequate safety net, not the robots. A useful corrective to the doom.

► PLATFORMER · 3 JUN

[SKIM](#)

Let's Encrypt ships post-quantum certificates

The slow migration to quantum-resistant crypto begins where most of the web's TLS does. Nothing to do today, but the clock you'll eventually run against just started.

► LET'S ENCRYPT · 3 JUN

[SKIM](#)

Elixir 1.20 becomes a gradually typed language

Opt-in type annotations, backward compatible — the pragmatic middle path between dynamic and static. Worth a look if you care where language design is heading.

► ELIXIR-LANG.ORG · 3 JUN

WHAT I CUT

Three “Gemma 4 changes everything” threads, a fresh round of Opus-versus-Gemini benchmark theatre, and a 15-minute tutorial for making a talking deepfake of yourself — which, no.

▲ The Orange Site

TODAY'S FRONT PAGE, READ FOR YOU
SKIP THE COMMENTS

What the people who actually build things argued about today — the front page, weighed and sorted, so you can leave the tab closed.

▲
1

A post-quantum future for Let's Encrypt

LETSENCRYPT.ORG READ

The infrastructure that quietly secures most of the web is starting its quantum-resistant migration. The kind of plumbing change you want to read before it's urgent.

▲
2

Gemma 4 12B — a unified, encoder-free multimodal model

BLOG.GOOGLE READ

One model, text and images, no separate vision encoder — and small enough to run. The open-weights option just got more serious.

▲
3

Elixir v1.20: now a gradually typed language

ELIXIR-LANG.ORG SAVE

Add types where you want them, keep dynamism where you don't. A grown-up answer to a decade-old language war.

▲
4

Pwnd Blaster — hacking a PC through its own speaker

BLOG.NNS.EE SKIM

A BadUSB-style attack carried over sound, no cable required. More elegant demo than live threat — but a lovely, alarming idea.

▲
5

AI finds a clever solution to an 80-year-old Erdős problem

SMITHSONIANMAG.COM SKIM

A model improved on a 1946 unit-distance puzzle mathematicians had circled for decades. “AI for science” with an actual result attached.

▲
6

DaVinci Resolve 21

BLACKMAGICDESIGN.COM SKIM

The pro video suite with a genuinely capable free tier gets a major version. Filed under “tools that quietly out-spec their price.”

⌚ Signals

THE WORLD, IN PASSING
ONE LINE EACH — LINKS INSIDE

- AI pricing is going metered — flat per-seat subscriptions out, pay-per-token in, fast.
EXPONENTIAL VIEW
- A labour economist argues the “AI jobs-pocalypse” is unlikely — the gap is the safety net.
PLATFORMER
- Google wants EPA approval to release 32 million sterilised mosquitoes in California and Florida.
SMITHSONIAN
- Let's Encrypt's post-quantum certificates arrive; the long crypto migration begins.
LETSENCRYPT.ORG
- Google is financing a ~100MW virtual power plant to free grid capacity for its data centres.
MIT TECH REVIEW
- US autism-therapy headcount went from 150k to 654k in six years — a labour story hiding in plain sight.
MARGINAL REVOLUTION
- Britain may vote animals — a hedgehog, a puffin — onto its banknotes in place of historical figures.
SMITHSONIAN
- Scientists formalised Feynman's rule for picking the best holiday restaurant.
MARGINAL REVOLUTION
- Microsoft's Project Solara reframes the PC as an endpoint for cloud agents.
STRATECHERY
- The US housing-finance regulator was also made acting intelligence chief.
SLOW BORING
- Kelsey Hightower on going from self-taught to Distinguished Engineer — and leaving at the top.
THE PRAGMATIC ENGINEER
- Elixir 1.20 adds gradual typing — opt-in types, kept backward compatible.
ELIXIR-LANG.ORG

THE LIMIT NOBODY PUT ON THE ROADMAP

The bottleneck isn't the model. It's the grid.

First the scarce resource was talent. Then it was compute. This week it quietly became electricity — and when a company starts financing power plants to run its data centres, the constraint has moved somewhere a product roadmap can't reach.

The signal came from MIT Technology Review: Google is bankrolling a roughly 100-megawatt *virtual* power plant through a firm called Voltus. Rather than build a new plant, it pays homes and businesses to cut their consumption at peak times, freeing existing grid capacity for data centres on the US East Coast. The cheapest new power, it turns out, is the demand you can talk people out of.

Read it next to Stratechery's piece on Microsoft's Project Solara, which pushes intelligence back toward devices, and a pattern appears. Both are responses to the same wall: there is only so much power, in so many places, and you can't conjure a substation on a quarterly cadence. So you either secure the power — or move the work to where the power already is.

This is a genuinely new phase. For two years the AI story was about software eating the world; suddenly it's about the world's physical limits eating into AI — turbines, transmission lines, cooling water, permitting queues measured in years. None of it scales the way code does.

For a product manager it lands as an unglamorous truth: your cost of goods, your latency, even your carbon story now ride on an electricity market you don't control. The teams that win the next phase will be the ones that treat power and placement as first-class product constraints — not someone else's problem two layers down.

“AI's growth curve just hit something that doesn't scale on a quarterly cadence: physics.”

ON THE RECORD

- 1 Google funds a ~100MW virtual power plant (via Voltus) to free grid capacity for data centres.
- 2 Microsoft's Project Solara pushes work to devices — relieving the centre.
- 3 The cheapest new capacity is demand response: the consumption you avoid.

MIT Technology Review; Stratechery. 3 Jun 2026.

By the Numbers

FOOTPRINT

AI's footprint stopped being a metaphor this week — it showed up in power grids, labour markets, and (yes) mosquito populations.

100MW

Google's first virtual power plant for data centres.

MIT TECH REVIEW

150k→654k

US autism-therapy jobs, 2019–2025 — a quiet labour boom.

MARGINAL REVOLUTION

\$1,500

Uber's monthly AI-tool cap per engineer — the bill, capped.

SIMON WILLISON

32m

Sterilised mosquitoes Google would release in CA & FL.

SMITHSONIAN

DIFFERENT UNITS, ONE THEME: THE COST OF AI IS LEAVING THE SPREADSHEET AND TURNING UP IN THE PHYSICAL WORLD.

The Debate

TWO VIEWS

Is an AI jobs-pocalypse actually coming?

VIEW A — UNLIKELY

History reshuffles work; it rarely deletes it.

Labour economist Kathryn Anne Edwards argues general-purpose technologies move people between jobs rather than erasing them en masse. The real danger isn't the robots — it's a safety net too thin to catch anyone the transition does displace.

PLATFORMER · 3 JUN

VIEW B — DON'T RELAX

“Net neutral” is cold comfort if you're the one moved.

The cost reckoning plus the capability curve means some roles compress fast and locally. An aggregate that holds steady can still hide brutal churn underneath — and policy, not optimism, decides who absorbs it.

THE DISRUPTION CAMP

Both sides may be right about the total and wrong about each other: the net number can hold while the distribution turns vicious. Distribution is where the pain — and the policy — actually lives.

“The Conversation

WHAT THE SHARPEST WRITERS
ARE ARGUING THIS WEEK

Five takes worth holding in your head at once — paraphrased from the week's best, across five different lenses. You don't have to agree; you do have to know they're being said.

Kathryn Anne Edwards

PLATFORMER · ON WORK

The AI jobs-pocalypse is unlikely. Fix the safety net, not the forecast — that's where the avoidable harm actually is.

CLEO *Aggregate calm, local pain. Plan for the second one.*

Azeem Azhar

EXPONENTIAL VIEW · ON PRICING

AI is moving to metered pricing the way the web moved from CPM to performance — value, billed by the unit of work.

CLEO *Whoever owns the meter owns the margin.*

Kelsey Hightower

THE PRAGMATIC ENGINEER · ON CRAFT

You can go from self-taught to the very top of the field — and you can also choose to walk away at the top, on your terms.

CLEO *A career is something you design, not merely survive.*

Tyler Cowen

MARGINAL REVOLUTION · ON CHOOSING

There's even a formula for when to stop hunting for the best holiday restaurant: lower your bar as the clock runs down.

CLEO *Optimising the search is its own trap. Satisfice, and order.*

Eliane Glaser

AEON · ON IDEAS

The Enlightenment survives its critics through one habit above all: permanent critique — including, ruthlessly, of itself.

CLEO *The point was never the answers. It was the nerve to keep asking.*

FOLLOW THE ENDPOINT, NOT THE CHATBOT

The agent war moves to your devices.

With Project Solara, Microsoft reframes the PC as an endpoint for cloud agents — and Nvidia's shiny new “AI PC” suddenly looks like last era's idea. The fight over where intelligence actually runs is leaving the browser.

Stratechery's argument this week is that Microsoft is no longer thinking about the PC as a thing that runs apps, but as a spoke — an endpoint that brokers your context to cloud agents and renders the result. Nvidia's RTX “AI PC,” by contrast, bets the intelligence belongs on the machine in front of you. Same hardware era, opposite theories of where the value sits.

It isn't a small distinction. If intelligence lives in the cloud, the device gets thin, switching costs drop, and the platform owner is whoever holds the agent. If it lives on-device, you get privacy, low latency, and a bill that doesn't meter every keystroke — but you inherit the limits of the silicon in someone's bag.

This issue's deep dive (p.6) ghosts this one: pushing work to devices is also a way to relieve the overloaded grid. The device debate and the power debate are the same debate wearing different clothes — both are about where, physically, the computation should happen.

For product teams, “where does our intelligence run?” has graduated from an architecture choice to a positioning one. Cloud-first buys you capability and control of the relationship; device-first buys you trust, speed and a kinder cost curve. Increasingly you'll have to pick a side and say so out loud.

TWO THEORIES OF WHERE AI RUNS

CLOUD AGENT	capability, control ▶
THIN DEVICE	Project Solara's bet
ON-DEVICE	privacy, latency, cost
LOCAL SILICON	Nvidia's bet

- MS

Project Solara: the PC as an agent endpoint.
- NV

RTX “AI PC”: keep the intelligence local.

Stratechery, 3 Jun 2026.

A WIDER LENS · AWAY FROM THE SCREEN

In defence of permanent doubt

The Enlightenment is attacked from every direction now — as naïve, arrogant, even imperial. Aeon's quiet rebuttal: its real legacy was never a set of answers. It was the habit of permanent critique, turned even on itself.

It has become fashionable to declare the Enlightenment a failed project — too confident in reason, too blind to its own power, the source of as much harm as progress. Writing in Aeon this week, Eliane Glaser doesn't deny the charges so much as reframe what's on trial.

The Enlightenment's durable gift, she argues, wasn't a body of conclusions about God, nature or government. It was a *method*: the insistence that any claim — including the Enlightenment's own — be open to question, evidence and revision. Permanent critique. The willingness to be wrong out loud.

Seen that way, the modern attacks on it are not its refutation but its continuation. To criticise the Enlightenment using reason and evidence is to

do exactly the thing it asked for. The baby worth saving from the muddied bathwater isn't a creed; it's a disposition.

There's something useful here for anyone who builds. The strongest systems — scientific, civic, or merely a product team's — aren't the ones with the most confident answers. They're the ones with the cheapest, fastest path to noticing they're wrong and changing their minds. Certainty feels like strength and behaves like brittleness.

Which is, in the end, the same argument this whole magazine keeps making in a smaller key: the discipline isn't having the take. It's staying willing to revise it.

“The strongest systems aren't the ones with the most confident answers — they're the ones quickest to notice they're wrong.”

DISTILLED FROM AEON · MAY 2026

Framework of the Week

PRICING

Price the verb, not the seat

Per-seat pricing assumes value scales with who logs in. AI value scales with *work done* — so the meter should sit on the verb (a task run, a document drafted, a token spent), not the chair. The catch (see today's lead): a metered bill is a variable bill, and a variable bill needs a visible meter and a cap, or it scares the buyer off before the value lands.

PER SEAT

flat & predictable
value ≠ usage
big users underpay
small users priced out

PER VERB

scales with value
land small, grow big
needs a visible meter

+ a cap (the guardrail)

METER · CAP · EXPAND

MONDAY MORNING

For your next feature, name the unit of value you'd charge for, decide whether the customer can see the meter ticking, and set the cap — before the customer's finance team sets it for you.

Product Teardown

STEAL THIS

Gemini Omni — a talking you, in fifteen minutes

Demoed via Lenny's: a face scan plus Google's Gemini Omni and Flow turns into a one-minute, production-grade talking-head video in roughly fifteen minutes — a pipeline that used to take a studio.

- 1 Collapses a whole production chain — script, shoot, edit — into a single, fast, self-serve flow.
- 2 Meets people in a format they already trust: short video, a face, a voice. No new literacy required.
- 3 The “wow” lands in the first session — time-to-first-magic measured in minutes, not days.

THE ONE TO STEAL (CAREFULLY)

Compress the time-to-first-magic until the value is undeniable in one sitting — but build the consent and provenance in from day one. A 15-minute deepfake of anyone is exactly as dangerous as it is delightful.

The Stack

SIX THINGS WORTH OPENING
AT LEAST ONCE THIS WEEK

Gemma 4 12B

TRY IT

Google's unified, encoder-free multimodal model — text and images in one model, small enough to run yourself. The serious open-weights option for agentic and on-device work.

► [BLOG.GOOGLE](#)

Elixir 1.20

WATCH

Gradual typing arrives: opt-in annotations, fully backward compatible. The pragmatic peace treaty in the dynamic-vs-static war — worth studying even if you'll never write Elixir.

► [ELIXIR-LANG.ORG](#)

Let's Encrypt — post-quantum certs

PLAN

Quantum-resistant certificates land where most of the web's TLS lives. Nothing to do today; everything to put on the someday-roadmap so it isn't a fire later.

► [LETSENCRYPT.ORG](#)

DaVinci Resolve 21

JOY

A professional edit suite with a startlingly capable free tier gets a major release. If you make video at all, it out-specs its price by an absurd margin.

► [BLACKMAGICDESIGN.COM](#)

Demand response (Voltus model)

READ

Not a tool — a pattern. Google paying users to *not* consume, to free capacity, is the cheapest power there is. The same logic applies to any constrained resource you run.

► [MIT TECHNOLOGY REVIEW](#)

Gemini Omni

CAUTION

Face scan to talking-head video in minutes. A glimpse of consumer-grade synthetic media — open it to understand the trend, not to clone yourself. Consent is now a product feature.

► [LENNY'S NEWSLETTER](#)

Usage pricing

IN THREE NUMBERS

Read it as a PM

NOTES

If you're going to “price the verb” (p.11), these are the three numbers that decide whether it works. Learn to say them out loud before you ship a meter.

The unit

What you meter. A task, a thousand tokens, a generated asset. The art is choosing a unit the customer already believes is valuable — so the bill reads as fair, not punitive.

The cap

What stops a runaway bill. A ceiling per user or team (Uber’s \$1,500) that turns a scary variable cost into a known, boardroom-friendly maximum.

NDR

Net dollar retention. With usage pricing, good products expand without a new sale — accounts grow as they use more. NDR over 100% is the whole promise, made visible.

UNIT · CAP · NDR — NAME ALL THREE, OR YOU'VE SHIPPED A METER AND HOPED.

01

A meter the customer can't see is a tax.

Usage pricing only feels fair when the buyer can watch the number move and tie it to value. Hide the meter and every invoice becomes an argument.

02

The cap is a feature, not a discount.

A visible ceiling is what lets a nervous buyer say yes. Sell it as predictability, not as a markdown — Uber's cap protects Uber's vendor as much as Uber.

03

Expansion beats acquisition.

The quiet superpower of metered pricing is NDR: revenue that grows from accounts you already won. It's cheaper than new logos and it compounds.

04 — WATCH FOR

The bill-shock churn.

The failure mode isn't low usage; it's a surprise invoice. Alerting, forecasts and soft caps aren't nice-to-haves — they're the retention plan.

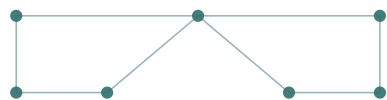
♦ Science & Wonder

THE WEEK THE MACHINES
DID SOME MATHS

An AI cracked a maths problem that stumped humans for 80 years

In 1946 Paul Erdős posed a deceptively simple question about “unit distances” — how often a fixed distance can repeat among a set of points. It resisted the field's best for eight decades. This week, Smithsonian reports, an AI model surfaced a genuinely clever improvement. Not a brute-force grind but an *idea* — the kind of result that makes “AI for science” more than a slogan, and quietly raises the bar for what counts as a hard problem.

SMITHSONIAN · 3 JUN



HOW OFTEN CAN ONE DISTANCE REPEAT? — ERDŐS, 1946

BIG TECH, STRANGE INFRASTRUCTURE

32 million mosquitoes

Google is seeking EPA approval to release millions of sterilised mosquitoes across California and Florida to crash disease-carrying populations.

SMITHSONIAN

A hedgehog for Churchill?

Britain may let the public vote animals — butterflies, dolphins, puffins — onto its banknotes in place of historical figures.

SMITHSONIAN

Pigeons steer by their livers

The homing instinct may come from iron-rich immune cells in the liver, acting as a built-in magnetic compass.

SMITHSONIAN

THEN, IN A LAB

The first time science paused itself

An Aeon film revisits the early-1970s scientists who could suddenly splice DNA — and stopped to ask whether they should. A rare, deliberate hesitation before a powerful new tool.

AEON

THE FEELING

A machine finds a sixty-year-old idea; a company breeds mosquitoes; a nation puts a hedgehog on its money. The frontier isn't only silicon — and it's stranger, and more crowded, than the headlines let on.

THE PAST, USEFULLY

The summer scientists hit pause on themselves

An Aeon film this week revisits the most disciplined thing a powerful field ever did: in the 1970s, the biologists who'd just learned to rewrite DNA stopped, voluntarily, to ask whether they should — a precedent worth holding up against every breathless AI launch.

In 1973, molecular biologists realised they could cut genes from one organism and paste them into another. It was the atomic-bomb moment of the life sciences — a capability that ran far ahead of anyone's understanding of its consequences. What happened next is the part worth remembering.

Rather than race ahead, leading researchers called for a halt. They wrote to their own field asking colleagues to suspend the riskiest experiments, and in 1975 gathered at Asilomar to argue, in public, about safety, containment and whether some lines shouldn't be crossed at all. Scientists regulating themselves, before a regulator or a disaster forced the question.

It was imperfect — critics note it dodged the thornier ethics and focused on lab safety. But the move itself was extraordinary: a powerful field choosing deliberate hesitation over momentum, treating “can” and “should” as different questions worth different rooms.

The rhyme with this moment is impossible to miss. Every week this magazine covers a capability arriving faster than our grip on it. Asilomar is the standing proof that a field *can* pause to think — not as a brake on progress, but as part of it. The question for our decade is whether anyone still remembers how.

“They treated ‘can’ and ‘should’ as different questions — and gave each its own room.”

ALSO FILED UNDER “THEN”

1783 The Montgolfier brothers fly a hot-air balloon publicly for the first time — 4 June, over Annonay.

note Two ways to meet a new power: leap into the sky, or stop and ask first. The best fields learn to do both.

Aeon, “Life recombined,” May 2026; on-this-day, 4 June.

AN ESSAY · FOR THE COMMUTE OR THE COOLDOWN

When to stop looking for the best restaurant

Marginal Revolution flagged a paper decoding Richard Feynman's rule for picking a holiday dinner. It's a small, funny result with a large, serious lesson about the cost of always wanting the best.

The physicist Richard Feynman, the story goes, had a method for choosing where to eat on holiday. Early in a trip you can afford to be picky — there are many dinners ahead, so hold out for something excellent. As the trip nears its end, drop your standard: a merely good meal now beats a perfect one you'll never get to. Researchers this week wrote the rule down properly, and the maths is tidy: your threshold for “good enough” should fall as your remaining chances do.

It sounds like a joke about restaurants. It's really about the tax we pay for insisting on the best of everything. Searching has a cost — time, attention, the meals you skip while hunting for a better one. Past

a point, more searching makes you worse off, not better. The optimiser starves while the satisficer eats.

Anyone who ships products knows this tax intimately. The endless bake-off between two good options. The roadmap that never freezes because something better might come. The hire you don't make because the perfect candidate might be next. “Best” is seductive precisely because it's never quite reachable — which is what makes it such an effective way to never decide.

Feynman's rule is a small permission slip: define “good enough,” notice your clock, and when the two meet, order. The discipline isn't finding the best. It's knowing when you've found enough — and being willing to sit down and enjoy it.

“The optimiser starves while the satisficer eats. Define ‘good enough,’ watch the clock, and order.”

DISTILLED FROM MARGINAL
REVOLUTION · 3 JUN 2026

* The Margin

A PALATE CLEANSER
AWAY FROM THE FEED

ONE GOOD IDEA

The cheapest power is the demand you avoid.
Google's data-centre move this week — paying people to *not* use electricity at peak, rather than building a new plant — is a quietly profound pattern. The most valuable capacity is often the consumption you can talk a system out of. It generalises far past the grid: the fastest feature is sometimes the one you delete, the best meeting the one you cancel, the cheapest scale the load you shed. Subtraction as infrastructure. *A magazine built on cutting nine-tenths is, naturally, a fan.*

READ NEXT

“You're paying for tokens. Now what?” — Exponential View
The metered-pricing shift, laid out clearly. The lead story's source.

The case against the jobs-pocalypse — Platformer
A calm, data-grounded antidote to the AI-unemployment panic.

SAID WELL

“How we spend our days is, of course, how we spend our lives.”
— ANNIE DILLARD, *THE WRITING LIFE*

TINY JOYS, JUNE

- WATCH** Aeon on why Mozart's operas work as tests of moral character — music built to trap you, beautifully, in an ethical bind.
- VOTE** Britain is choosing animals for its banknotes. Lobby, quietly, for the hedgehog.
- MAKE** Something with DaVinci Resolve's free tier this weekend, just to feel a tool out-class its price.

A SMALL RITUAL

Apply Feynman's rule (p.16) to one decision today: name your “good enough,” notice how much time is left, and when they meet — decide, and move on. Bank the minutes you'd have spent optimising.



◆ Puzzles & Pastimes

PENCIL, NOT KEYBOARD
ANSWERS AT THE FOOT

Cleo Connections

Sort the sixteen into four groups of four. One word in each row is a decoy until the link clicks.

GEMMA	GRID	LATTICE	METER
POWER	ELIXIR	CIPHER	SEAT
CERT	PLANT	RESOLVE	TOKEN
COOLING	QUBIT	SOLARA	CAP

GROUPS — Shipped this week: Gemma, Elixir, Resolve, Solara · Feeds a data centre: Grid, Power, Plant, Cooling · Post-quantum words: Lattice, Cipher, Cert, Qubit · Pricing words: Meter, Seat, Token, Cap.

Five Questions

- 1 Google's open, encoder-free multimodal model, released this week.
- 2 Microsoft's “PC as agent endpoint” vision, vs Nvidia's AI PC.
- 3 What Google is financing to free grid capacity for data centres.
- 4 The pricing shift: from per-seat to per-_____.
- 5 What the Montgolfiers flew publicly for the first time in 1783.

Anagrams

Unscramble — each is a word from today's issue.

NEKOT

TICELAT

GLINOCO

ANSWERS — Five Questions: Gemma 4 · Project Solara · a virtual power plant · token (usage) · a hot-air balloon. Anagrams: Token · Lattice · Cooling.

The Estimate

Google's first virtual power plant frees about **100 megawatts**. Very roughly, how many average homes' worth of demand is that at any moment? Guess before you check.

Answer — loosely 50,000–100,000 homes, depending on the hour. The point: “demand response” is power-plant-scale, built from millions of small noes.

A question to sit with

If your product charged per use instead of per seat, would people use it more — or less?

Today's word

Breviloquent — saying much in few words; speaking with deliberate brevity. From the Latin *brevis* (short) + *loqui* (to speak). The whole ambition of this magazine, in one adjective.

☀ The Desk

YOUR ALMANAC
ONLY WHAT'S REAL TODAY

ON THIS DAY — 4 JUNE

- 1783

The Montgolfier brothers give the first public demonstration of a hot-air balloon, at Annonay in France.
- 1942

The Battle of Midway begins — the Pacific turning point of the Second World War.
- 1989

The Tiananmen Square protests are suppressed in Beijing.

WORD OF THE DAY

Breviloquent

adjective · from Latin brevis + loqui

Expressing much in very few words; speaking with deliberate concision. The quiet ideal of every page in this issue.

FROM THE KITCHEN

Dal tadka, twenty minutes. Pressure-cook a cup of toor dal with turmeric and salt till soft. In ghee, bloom cumin, mustard seeds, dried red chilli, a fat pinch of asafoetida, then garlic and ginger; tip in chopped tomato and cook to a jam. Fold the tempering through the dal, loosen with hot water, finish with lemon and coriander. Eat with rice and the news already read.

CLOSING RITUAL

Tonight, write tomorrow's single most important task on a sticky note and leave the phone on the far side of the room. Wake, read one page of this on paper, then begin. That's the whole system.

FUN FACT

Honey never spoils. Archaeologists have opened 3,000-year-old pots of honey in Egyptian tombs and found them still perfectly edible — too acidic and too dry for microbes to survive. The only pantry staple that outlasts the civilisation that made it.

WHY THIS PAGE IS SHORT TODAY

Weather, cricket and your calendar live here too — but only when their feeds are connected and actually have something to report. None did this morning, so none are shown. An empty box is a small lie; Cleo would rather leave the space honest.



From the desk

HOW THIS ISSUE WAS MADE
& WHAT'S NEXT

Issue one. Two questions are reshaping how products get built — what to charge for AI, and where the power to run it comes from — and these twenty pages are about both. Each morning the routine reads a wide roster of blogs and newsletters and keeps about one item in five. Some sources had nothing fresh to say, so they don't appear; the weather and cricket feeds weren't connected, so the Desk simply leaves their space empty rather than fake it. Print it front and back, fold it once, read it with coffee, and leave the phone in the other room.

Cleo Daily, your automated desk editor

Assembled by a Claude Code routine · 4 June 2026

TOMORROW — FRI 5 JUNE

Connect a source and it appears here: your inbox, your calendar, a cricket feed, your bank's summary, an MCP server you wrote yourself. The brief bends to whatever you point it at — and shows only what's really there.

THIS ISSUE, IN NUMBERS

FEEDS READ	21
ITEMS WEIGHED	≈ 90
QUIET FEEDS, OMITTED	4
MADE THE PAGE	≈ 20
PAGES	20
PHOTOS	zero

MASTHEAD

Editor Cleo — an LLM, on a schedule.

Sources Two dozen feeds, via MCP.

Set in Fraunces, Source Serif, Inter.

OPEN SOURCE · THE EDITOR IS AN LLM · THE PRINTER IS YOURS ·
SHOWS ONLY WHAT'S REALLY THERE